dynasty that succeeded them, the little-known Andhra Ikshvakus.

In the middle of the second century CE the fortunes of the Satavahanas began to decline. The eastern Deccan fell to the Ikshvakus, who took over the Krishna and Godavari valleys and made Nagarjunakonda their capital. Their origins are uncertain. One theory is that their founder Siri Camtamula was an invader from the North, but two of the epithets given to them in the Puranas – Sriparvateya, meaning ‘of the forest’, and Andhrabhrtyas, or ‘servants of the Satavahanas’ – suggest that they are more likely to have been local tribal people who rose up against their masters. Unlike the Satavahanas, the Ikshvakus were overtly Buddhist and for a hundred years they presided over the continuing spread of Madyamaka Buddhism, supporting new monastic centres such as Phanigiri and enlarging existing ones such as Amaravati and Kanaganahalli. It was at this time that the first iconic – that is to say human rather than symbolic images – portrayals of the Buddha began to make their first appearance in south and central India.

Little is known about these Andhra Ikshvakus, but we know even less about the mysterious Kalabhras who may – or may not – have followed them, and who are said to have been responsible for a supposed ‘dark age’ that engulfed the Tamil South over this same period. Until recently historians used to speak of a two-and-a-half-century ‘Kalabhra interregnum’ that disrupted the ancient lines of the Chola, Pandya and Chera kings between the end of the third century and the sixth century, their most prominent king ruling in the last quarter of the fifth century under the name Vikranthaha or ‘idol destroyer’. References to these Kalabhras are invariably hostile, describing them as ‘enemies of civilisation’ and as ‘evil kings who brought chaos and took away the rights of the Brahmins’, because from their point of view the Kalabhras were heretics who destroyed Brahminical culture. They appear to have entered